

Secrets behind serving customers with purpose

How leadership and career meaningfulness drive customer-oriented behaviors

In today's fast-paced and ever-evolving business landscape, organizations in the hospitality industry are increasingly recognizing the importance of customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. These behaviors are crucial for enhancing customer satisfaction, improving service delivery, and ultimately driving organizational success, and are ultimately driven by leadership. As Larry Ellison, CEO of Oracle put it, '*leadership is about making others better as a result of your presence and making sure that impact lasts in your absence.*'

A research paper by [Saeed et al. \(2025\)](#) explores the relationship between managers' servant leadership and frontline employees' customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors, with a focus on the impact of career meaningfulness and of work centrality. Data for this study was collected through a survey questionnaire directed at three-to-five-star hotels in Pakistan, which was answered by the 245 respondent frontline employees and their managers.

The core concepts

Servant leadership is a leadership style that emphasizes serving others, prioritizing the needs of employees and customers, and fostering a culture of empathy and support. It's about creating an environment where employees feel valued and empowered, which in turn drives their performance and commitment.

Career meaningfulness refers to the extent to which individuals perceive their careers as significant and aligned with their broader life purpose and well-being. Extending beyond job satisfaction alone, it also includes seeing one's career as a vital part of personal identity and fulfillment.

Work centrality is the degree that work is central to an individual's life and identity. So work centrality encompasses the deep sense of purpose and identity that individuals derive from their work, which can significantly influence someone's behavior and performance.

Revealing the results

The survey was conducted at three different points in time to allow for a comprehensive analysis of the relationships between servant leadership, career meaningfulness, work centrality, and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. Some example question prompts that respondents rated included: "My leader puts my best interests ahead of his/her own" (servant leadership), and "the major satisfaction in my life comes from my job" (work centrality).

The four main results from the study are as follows:

1. **Servant leadership and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors** – the study found a positive association between servant leadership and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. This is because servant leadership fosters a supportive work environment that empowers employees to meet customer expectations and embody their organization's values. By addressing employees' needs and providing a supportive work environment then, managers instill a sense of superior service delivery and thus represent their organization to customers.
2. **The impact of career meaningfulness** – career meaningfulness was found to impact the relationship between servant leadership and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. The explanation for this is that servant leadership enhances employees' career meaningfulness by providing a supportive work environment and addressing their needs. This sense of meaningfulness in turn motivates employees to invest their resources in customer-oriented behaviors, so enhances their performance and creativity.
3. **Work Centrality and its impact** – the positive association between career meaningfulness and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors was stronger at high levels of work centrality and insignificant at low levels of work centrality. This can be explained with the dynamic that employees with high work centrality view work as a core part of their self-concept, which amplifies the motivational impact of career meaningfulness on their behaviors. In contrast, when work centrality is low, the motivational power of career meaningfulness weakens to the level of being immaterial.
4. **Indirect impacts** – the indirect effect of servant leadership on customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors via career meaningfulness was significant when work centrality was high but not significant when work centrality was low. But why? Because employees with high work centrality are more competent in utilizing servant leadership that could develop their career meaningfulness, which then facilitates them to serve customers while representing their organizations to deal with the customers effectively.

Action steps for managers

Managers and organizations can leverage the findings of this study to enhance employee performance and customer satisfaction. Here is some actionable managerial guidance for gaining traction along this path, to:

- **Exhibit servant leadership behaviors:** Managers should exhibit servant leadership behaviors to enhance frontline employees' sense of career meaningfulness and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors. This can be achieved by working on creating a supportive work environment, addressing employees' needs, and fostering a culture of empathy and support.
- **Prioritize work centrality:** Organizations will benefit from prioritizing work centrality when hiring frontline employees and implementing training programs to cultivate work centrality. Doing so can help employees derive a deep sense of purpose and identity

By addressing employees' needs and providing a supportive work environment then, managers instill a sense of superior service delivery.

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from their work, which can significantly influence their behavior and performance in a positively value-adding direction.

- **Enhance career meaningfulness:** Better managers focus on enhancing employees' career meaningfulness by providing opportunities for career growth, ensuring equal opportunities for promotion, and preventing discrimination in the reward system. Ensuring this is happening in all teams will likely motivate employees to invest their resources in customer-oriented behaviors, thereby enhancing their performance and creativity.

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Comment

The review is based on "Understanding career-meaningfulness and work centrality to serve customers: servant leadership and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors" (2025) by Munazza Saeed *et al.*, published in *Career Development International*.

Reference

Saeed, M., Bani-Melhem, A.J., Hassan, H., Alvi, T.H. and Altaf, S. (2025), "Understanding career-meaningfulness and work centrality to serve customers: servant leadership and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors", *Career Development International*, Vol. 30 No. 2, pp. 205-220, doi: [10.1108/CDI-01-2024-0039](https://doi.org/10.1108/CDI-01-2024-0039).

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